

Behind the Dimmock Line, General Beauregard's Confederate defenders waited nervously. The assault launched that evening was so overwhelming that the triumphant Union troops captured great stretches of the Dimmock Line, forcing Beauregard back to find another defensible position. For a moment, Smith held the key to Petersburg, but he let it slip from his grasp. Convinced that more Confederates opposed him than was actually the case, he failed to follow up his success. Beauregard hastily dug a second line of defense, his men frantically scraping the earth with bayonets and tin cups, while Grant pushed his generals to "carry Petersburg before the enemy could reinforce its garrison."

Lee was initially confused. "I do not know the position of Grant's army," he wrote to his superiors in Richmond the next day. But Beauregard, now fending off more than 40,000 enemy troops, identified the blue-clad soldiers confronting him as belonging to the Army of the Potomac. On receiving that news, Lee sent his veterans down the road to Petersburg.

2,500 The approximate number of troops at Beauregard's disposal to man the defenses of Petersburg on June 15, 1864. Many of them were old men and young boys of the militia.